

problem-solving. We are more likely to do or add more to solve problems rather than take something away, which is why it's so easy to get us to buy stuff! And it's a contributing factor to why life and our environment feel so complex.

## Choosing Complicated

This tends to be the default for us for many different reasons. Sometimes we attach value to being busy. We can feel more important if we're productive, which can also be tied to a deeply rooted fear of disappointing others or ourselves.

Another explanation for our propensity toward complicated is a little something called complexity bias, a common cognitive bias that predisposes us to prefer complex solutions over simple ones. In the case of complexity bias, we skip over an easy fix or explanation, assuming it must be more nuanced and intricate, so we'll select "complex" even when we don't need to. This happens in all aspects of our lives from product purchases and relationship statuses to investment choices. It's especially interesting because biases exist as an effort to *save* mental energy, and yet, unfortunately, when left unchecked, they can cost us.

One of the most harmful consequences of complexity bias is our tendency to refuse to learn new things because we think they're going to be too complicated. This is me with anything tech or computer related. Literally anytime something is not working "how it should," I melt into a puddle and immediately call it IMPOSSIBLE! Until I decide to just turn it off and turn it back on again. Problem solved. We also see this bias crop up when it comes to investing. It feels overwhelming. There are acronyms we don't understand. There are even people whose job it is to tell us it's complicated, so we pay them to invest for us.

Marketers also know this about human psychology and will take full advantage of it to make a sale. In the toiletries section of the store I (Jill) saw products boasting "microbiome nutrient serum" and "100 percent pure unrefined first-pressed." Few of us actually know what the heck all that means, and our lack of understanding leads us to believe "It must be good! Imma buy that!"